Dyad

Overview

The Problem

Many years ago, there existed initiatives around the world called pen pal programs that connected all kinds of people together through letters. In the modern day, these programs are almost non-existent. There are a few reasons for this, but the biggest one is that people no longer want to talk just for the sake of talking. In this increasingly connected world, life moves at a higher velocity than ever. No one has time to stop to chat just for the sake of it. So how do people make meaningful connections now? They don’t; not unless they have actively shared interests or often meet each other at places where they already have things to do. Students make friends at school only. Most working adults make new friends at work only. But what about those who work from home? What about retirees and the unable to work?

THE EVIDENCE | Why Dyad matters

17.1% → 20.9% · Loneliness is rising

One might think that in a world where we're more connected than ever, loneliness would be becoming less of a problem. But the numbers tell a different story. Between early 2023 and mid-2025, the share of American adults who felt significantly lonely for much of the previous day actually rose from 17.1% to 20.9%. That's an increase of 3.8 percentage points in just over two years.

32% vs. 20% · Connection beyond the workplace

But what about the people who don't have a workplace to go to? In Gallup's global research, 32% of unemployed adults said they had felt lonely a lot the previous day, compared with 20% of employed adults. Of course, that doesn't mean unemployment itself is necessarily what makes someone lonely. But it does make you wonder how much we rely on work just to have people around us.

+31% dementia risk · Loneliness has consequences

And loneliness isn't just an unpleasant feeling, either. It may be connected to something much more serious. A 2024 analysis drawing on 21 studies and more than 600,000 participants found that lonely people had a 31% higher hazard of developing dementia. For Alzheimer's disease specifically, the estimated increase was 39%. These are relative risks found in observational research, so they don't prove loneliness causes either disease. But they're difficult numbers to ignore.

3% → 17% · Fewer close friendships

It's not only how lonely people feel, though. There's also the question of how many close friends people actually have. In 1990, just 3% of Americans surveyed said they had no close friends outside their family. In a 2024 survey, that number was 17%. The two surveys weren't conducted in exactly the same way, so we can't treat the difference as a perfect measurement. Still, it's quite a striking contrast. What happened to all those friendships?

51% · Friendship through shared activities

So where do friendships actually happen? In a 2021 American survey, 51% said they had friends they did things with, whether that meant sports, hobbies, volunteering, or other activities. Among people with close friends, 54% had made one through work and 47% through school, while 19% had made one through a club or organization. Only 8% reported making a close friend online. These categories overlap, but the pattern is interesting: so many of our friendships seem to begin somewhere we're already doing something together.

WHY AN ACTIVITY-FIRST APPROACH?

This leads to an interesting question: what if the problem isn't just finding people to talk to, but finding a reason to spend time with them? Research on friendships among Dartmouth students suggests that being near someone and having repeated opportunities to interact both matter when friendships form. That makes sense to me. It's much easier to get to know someone when you're doing something together than when you're simply expected to make conversation with a stranger. That's the idea Dyad wants to explore: not just connecting people, but giving them something to connect over. Whether that actually works is what we'd need to test.

One thing worth keeping in mind is that these studies don't all measure loneliness or friendship in the same way, and some examine Americans while others look at people worldwide. The Alzheimer's and dementia figures also describe an association, rather than proving that loneliness causes these diseases.

The Solution

Dyad is a platform that attempts to solve the loneliness epidemic plaguing a wide variety of people in the world, from students to the elderly. Our solution tackles the problem by acknowledging the need for people to be both proximate and active when they’re making friends.

Now, recall that only 8% of Americans with close friends in the survey reported having made a close friend online, compared with 19% who had made one through a club or organization. At first, that might seem like a pretty discouraging statistic for a platform whose purpose is to connect people. But that's exactly the point of Dyad: we don't want people to stay on our platform. We want to get them OFF it, and out into the real world.

Rather than trying to make people form meaningful relationships through a screen, Dyad wants to be what gets them into the environments where those relationships can actually grow. If we

can help move someone from the 'online' category into clubs, organizations, events, and other shared experiences, maybe we can create an entirely new way for people to make friends. One that doesn't rely on already being in the same school, workplace, or social circle.

How would it actually work? Imagine there's a music festival coming up in San Diego. Dyad finds the event and shows it to people who might enjoy it. Someone sees it, decides they'd like to go, and marks themselves as interested in finding company. They can invite someone else who's interested, or leave themselves available for an invitation. Once somebody accepts, they have a group with a real plan, rather than yet another conversation about what they should do someday.

The group doesn't have to stop at two people, either. Other interested users can request to join or be invited, and everyone can talk together before the event. That way, the first time they meet doesn't have to feel like the first time they've ever spoken. And since the activity already has a place and time, much of the usual back-and-forth planning is avoided. There's still some coordination to do, of course, but at least nobody has to come up with an activity from scratch.

There are two ways for an activity to appear on Dyad. It can be an event listed by an established organizer, like a concert or festival, or it can be something a user wants to do themselves: going thrifting, playing basketball, visiting a museum, or really anything else. Both lead to the same result: a chance to find people to do it with. Users can distinguish official event listings from community-created activities and decide what they're comfortable joining.

But meeting once isn't the whole goal. Imagine that the festival ends and you actually got along with the people you met. Why should that be the end of it? Dyad should make it easy to reconnect, see what else you might all enjoy, and go somewhere together again. Because the point isn't to collect as many introductions as possible. It's to give a new friendship the opportunity to become a lasting one.

That's the real difference I want Dyad to make. Instead of asking two strangers to become friends just because an algorithm thinks they're compatible, it gives them a reason to meet and something to experience together. If a friendship develops from there, that's even better. And if it doesn't, they still got to do something they wanted to do.

RESEARCH SOURCES | Overview

Gallup (2025), significant daily loneliness:
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Luchetti et al. (2024), loneliness and dementia meta-analysis: https://www.nature.com/articles/s44220-024-00328-9

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https://www.americansurveycenter.org/research/disconnected-places-and-spaces/

Survey Center on American Life (2021), State of American Friendship:
https://www.americansurveycenter.org/research/the-state-of-american-friendship-change-challenges-and-loss/

Marmaros & Sacerdote (2006), How Friendships Form: https://research.google/pubs/how-friendships-form/

Pitch and spirit

THE THREE LAYERS OF DYAD

The problem: People want meaningful connections, but making new friends is difficult, and the places where friendships often form aren't accessible to everyone.
The insight: Friendships have a better chance to grow when people share experiences, not when they're simply placed in front of a stranger and expected to connect.
The solution: Dyad helps people discover something they already want to do, find others who want to do it too, and actually go together.

Dyad starts with a reason to connect and helps users find the people.

We don't want people endlessly scrolling through Dyad. We want them to get off the app and into the real world—and come back when they're ready for their next experience.
Dyad doesn't ask you to make a friend first and find something to do afterward. It gives you something to do and lets the friendship happen naturally.
Success isn't just two people meeting once. It's those same people wanting to see each other again.
Phrases to use that convey the spirit of the app:

- Dyad doesn’t perpetuate the usual “for you” slop by giving you what’s viral or trending; it only presents you with real people wanting to make real connections.
- Dyad removes the distance and tension between users that exist on other platforms like Tinder, allowing them to truly connect
- Dyad doesn’t force purposeless hangouts. Instead, it ensures two users who connect have something to do together